

Admin Account Compromise with Data Exfiltration

SEVERITY

Critical

THREAT SCORE

95/100

STATUS

Investigating

CLASSIFICATION

Genuine Threat

CONFIDENCE

95%

RELATED ALERTS

6 (Firewall, SIEM Platform +2 more)

1 BLUF — BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT

BOTTOM LINE: Admin account compromised with data exfiltration in progress

SEVERITY: Critical

CONFIDENCE: 90%

KEY EVIDENCE: 23 failed logins followed by successful access; 4.2GB download from finance directory; Unauthorized SSH key addition; Outbound connection to uncommon destination

MITRE ATT&CK: T1110 Brute Force; T1078 Valid Accounts; T1021 Remote Services; T1041 Exfiltration Over C2 Channel

IMMEDIATE ACTION: Isolate server-01 from network and change all admin credentials

NEXT INVESTIGATION: Determine what specific data was exfiltrated and identify if the attacker has established persistence

2 MITRE ATT&CK MAPPING

T1110	Brute Force	[Credential Access]
T1078	Valid Accounts	[Defense Evasion, Persistence, Privilege Escalatio...]
T1021	Remote Services	[Lateral Movement]
T1041	Exfiltration Over C2 Channel	[Exfiltration]

3 RISK SIGNALS

- +20 Privileged account involved
- +15 Multiple failed logins
- +15 Unknown/unusual source IP
- +15 Successful login after failures
- +20 Large or unusual data transfer
- +25 Known malicious IOC match
- +10 Multiple correlated sources

4 ANALYST EXPLANATION

A clear attack pattern shows brute force login attempts followed by successful access, large data download, and unauthorized SSH key addition. The attacker gained admin privileges and immediately began exfiltrating sensitive data.

[Analyst] Isolated server-01 from the network, credentials rotated. Escalated to IR team lead.

5 RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

- 1 Isolate server-01 from network immediately
- 2 Reset all admin credentials and review authorized_keys
- 3 Identify what data was downloaded from /exports/finance
- 4 Scan all systems for additional compromised accounts

6 KEY EVIDENCE

- + A1001: 23 failed login attempts from external IP
- + A1003: Successful SSH login from new location
- + A1004: 4.2 GB download from finance directory
- + A1006: Unauthorized SSH key added to admin account

7 RELATED ALERT TIMELINE

- 2026-09-14 05:26:26Z [Firewall] multiple_failed_logins (A1001)**
23 failed login attempts against admin account from external IP 103.44.17.9
- 2026-09-14 05:27:26Z [SIEM Platform] brute_force_anomaly (A1002)**
Anomaly rule: login failure rate for admin exceeded baseline by 12x
- 2026-09-14 05:30:26Z [Authentication] successful_login (A1003)**
Successful SSH login for admin from 103.44.17.9 (first login from this country)
- 2026-09-14 05:36:26Z [File Server] large_data_download (A1004)**
4.2 GB downloaded by admin account from /exports/finance (unusual volume)
- 2026-09-14 05:41:26Z [Authentication] account_manipulation (A1006)**
New SSH key added to admin account authorized_keys from session on server-01
- 2026-09-14 05:44:26Z [Firewall] outbound_connection (A1005)**
Outbound connection from server-01 to 91.240.118.6 on port 4444 (uncommon destination)